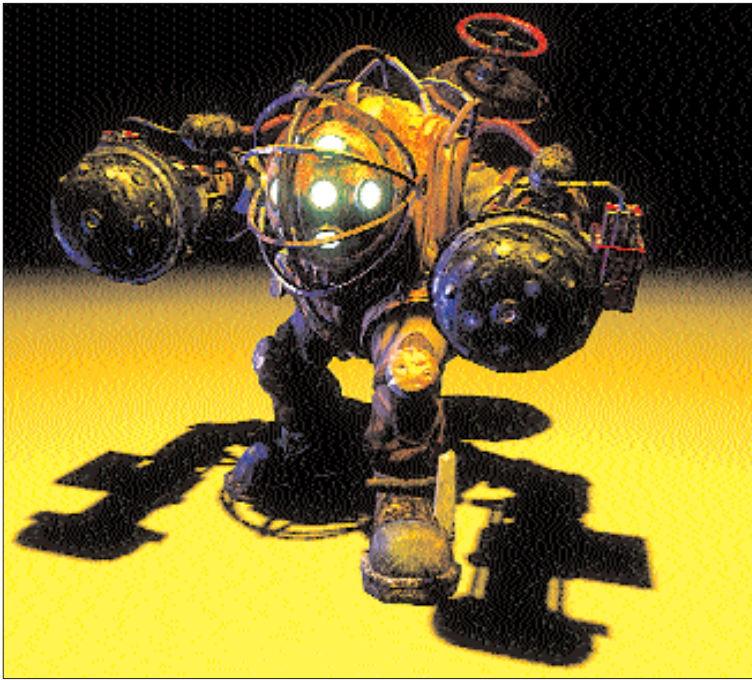




Another aspect of realism is AI. Several titles today like *F.E.A.R.* and *S.T.A.L.K.E.R.* feature good AI models, which make for a believable gaming experience as characters in the game world react more realistically to your actions as a character. AI is not limited to games of the first person genre. A good example would be *Company of Heroes*, a gorgeous looking RTS (Real Time Strategy) game based on the World War II scenario. Enemy AI is challenging, with enemy squads actually trying to flank you, throwing grenades, calling for artillery support and so on.

Work in progress should see games featuring characters that actually populate a game world, and go about their activities independent of interaction with your character—this is one aspect of realism where most games trip up! In *S.T.A.L.K.E.R.* (a realistic first person shooter), packs of mutant dogs will roam around, not necessarily attacking you just because you're well armed. Drop your AK-74 and you're toast! Similarly, rival stalkers will back away from a firefight they're losing, only to regroup and follow you looking for an ambush opportunity.

Upcoming games like *Crysis* and *BioShock* promise even more immersive action. Non-linear storylines, lifelike realism, and ferocious

enemy AI, along with a deep storyline that promises to engross as no movie ever can. Further down the game release path there are psychological thrillers like *Alan Wake* that promise to leave the hair on your nape standing and your psyche on edge. Let's take a look at *BioShock*, the dubbed the spiritual successor to *System Shock*—one of the earlier games that brought terms like "atmospheric" and "immersive" to games.

BioShock takes you to the city of Rapture—a deserted futuristic city built on the bottom of the sea and isolated from it by a massive dome like shell—basically a scientific

experiment gone wrong. What we've seen of gameplay demos showcase extremely realistic visuals and sound—this game will involve you with sheer attention to detail. Your character will move thorough a slowly deteriorating world, where water seeps in through cracks in the outer shell as the sea tries to reclaim what was it's. This world under water world is brought to life with life-like textures, HDR and bloom, not to mention eerie sounds like a radio playing in an abandoned bar, or the creak of a rusty hinge somewhere upstairs.

A little background information... *BioShock* has these little girls (called little sisters) who harvest adam, which is priceless valuable and the only thing you use to upgrade your looks, physical and combat skills, and your 50-odd powers, including telekinesis, or something much more weird like shooting a bunch of wasps out of your hands to be used as projectiles! Now these little sisters are defenseless, but protected fiercely by big daddies, one of the toughest entities in the game.

The combat in this game will also be very realistic, not to mention absolutely open-ended... This snippet of gameplay was showcased in a recently released video—in a fight

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